Mutesi “Tesi” Rusagara

(roo-sah-GAH-rah)

Minister of State for Resource Mobilization and Public Investment
Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **June 2024**

Tesi Rusagara is a rising technocrat who combines international expertise with a deep commitment to national development.

- **Rising Star**
  Appointed when she was 34 years old,, she had already led major institutions including Kigali Innovation City and the Agaciro Development Fund, Rwanda's sovereign wealth fund.

- **Versatile Technocrat**
  Rusagara’s background in business, technology, and policy– a “mismatch of different sectors,” in her words–has enabled her to see the big picture.

Rusagara believes in paying it forward, seeking opportunities for young Rwandans, especially women, to gain economic power and ascend to senior positions.

WHY THEY MATTER

Rusagara plays a pivotal role in Rwanda's efforts to mobilize domestic and international resources, reduce aid dependency, and attract strategic investment in priority sectors.

- **Increasing Agricultural Productivity**
  In her previous position as Agaciro CEO, she backed a joint venture to build a state-of-the-art fertilizer factory to increase crop yield and another project to strengthen food systems for producers and smallholder farmers.

- **Delivering Climate Benefits**
  Rusagara launched Rwanda’s Climate and Nature Finance Strategy, which seeks to accelerate public and private sector investments in climate action and biodiversity conservation. She also supports Rwanda Green Fund’s partnership to develop Article 6 carbon credit projects.

Rusagara reminds counterparts that they must partner with Rwanda on "our vision, not on your terms." Her goal is to position Rwanda as a leading innovation hub while strengthening its financial independence.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Rusagara is a thoughtful interlocutor who adopts a serious tone when evaluating new opportunities while remaining personable and engaging.

- **A Disciplined Interlocutor**
  Rusagara is a strategic thinker who often responds to questions in a structured manner, enumerating her views in a three-part structure and using examples to illustrate her key points.

- **A Friendly and Open Attitude**
  While professional, Rusagara uses a conversational style to win over counterparts. Her disposition is often warm and positive, referencing personal experiences and inspirational stories about Rwanda.

Rusagara has talked about the importance of being confident in her meetings, sharing that it is important to "not being afraid to speak up" and not to care about "sticking out as a sore thumb in the room."

ON THEIR MIND

- **Strong Economic Growth**
  Rwanda's economy grew 11.8 percent in Q3 2025, with the IMF praising the country's resilience despite global headwinds. S&P affirmed Rwanda's B+/B credit rating with a stable outlook.

- **Critical Minerals**
  Rwanda is overhauling its mining laws and tax structures to transition from a raw ore exporter to a regional processing hub for critical transition minerals like tantalum, tungsten and niobium.

- **Regional Economic Integration Framework (REIF)**
  Rwanda is working with U.S. and European partners to implement the Regional Economic Integration Framework (REIF), a new initiative aimed at deepening economic ties and fostering stability in the Great Lakes region.

- **New Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) Plan**
  Rwanda in November released NDC 3.0, outlining climate actions for the period 2025–2035. This includes $7 billion for climate adaptation measures and $4.9 billion to support mitigation efforts to reduce greenhouse gas emissions.

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NETWORK

She maintains active connections with international development organizations and private sector partners, particularly in innovation and finance sectors.

Her time at Stanford and Deloitte Consulting has given her strong networks in Silicon Valley and global finance, which she leverages to support Rwanda's development goals. In June 2025, she led Rwanda's delegation to the AIIB Annual Meetings in Beijing, meeting with the Bank's President and Chinese development institutions.

Rusagara has cultivated strong relationships within Rwanda's technocratic circles and has earned President Kagame's trust through successive high-profile appointments.

Her appointments to key financial positions—including leadership of the Agaciro Development Fund and her current ministerial role, as well as her earlier time in the Office of the President—suggests strong support from President Kagame. Rusagara works closely with Finance Minister Yusuf Murangwa, frequently representing Rwanda together at international forums including World Bank/IMF meetings.

CONTROVERSIES

While maintaining a generally positive reputation, Rusagara's rapid rise and relative youth have occasionally raised questions about her experience level.

- **Age and Experience**
  In her mid-thirties, she is notably young for her level of responsibility, though supporters point to her international education and diverse experience in both public and private sectors.

- **Balancing Act**
  Her emphasis on reducing aid dependency while seeking foreign investment has required careful diplomatic navigation to maintain relationships with traditional development partners.

Rusagara has bristled when people overly focus on her age, reminding them that she is older than most people in Rwanda where the median age is 19.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of State for Resource Mobilization and Public Investment**, Government of Rwanda (2024 to present)
- **Chief Executive Officer**, Agaciro Development Fund (2023 to 2024)
- **Managing Director**, Kigali Innovation City (2019 to 2023)
- **Senior Consultant**, Deloitte Consulting (2017 to 2019)
- **Economic Policy Unit**, Office of the President (2013 to 2015)
- **Investor Relations**, Bank of Kigali (2011 to 2012)

BIO

Tesi Rusagara represents a new generation of Rwandan leaders who came of age during the country's post-genocide reconstruction period. Born circa 1990, she pursued international education before returning home to contribute to Rwanda's development.

- **Global Experience**
  She holds an MBA from Stanford University (2015-2017) and a Bachelor of Business Science in Finance from the University of Cape Town (2007-2010). Her time in Silicon Valley shaped her approach to innovation and investment.

- **Rwandan Pride**
  Rusagara takes pride in her work in Rwanda, saying that she always wanted to come back home because "one of the privileges we have as a country is that we have a very big ambition, a very big vision."

Rusagara speaks English and Kinyarwanda. Her Pinterest account suggests that she is conscientious about her professional presentation and interested in fashion hacks.

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